

Research Topic Brainstorming:

Make a list of 7-10 topic ideas. Put these ideas in order of importance (only you can determine their importance).

- Why people tend to stick to their beliefs even when presented with evidence that clearly contradicts those beliefs
- How social media algorithms influence the way we form opinion
- The psychology behind why conspiracy theories are created and why they are able to spread so quickly
- Why loneliness is increasing in spite of being connected via social media
- How music impacts our mental health and how it allows us to process emotions
- Why some individuals thrive under stress while others completely break down
- How the experiences of an individual during their childhood will impact the types of relationships they develop as adults
- The ways in which true crime media influences how members of society perceive actual crime
- Why sleep deprivation has become accepted in the college environment and the negative effects it can cause to students

Choose 3 topics and finish the following sentences for each:

Topic 1

2-3 things I am absolutely certain of...

Firstly, I am aware of a psychological phenomenon in which corrective misinformation may actually strengthen previously held beliefs. Second, I am aware that identity plays a huge role, when beliefs are tied to who you are and who your community is, letting go of those beliefs is nearly impossible. Third, I am aware that virtually all humans are affected, no one is immune, regardless of intelligence or logic.

What I know comes from...

A combination of different sources. My AP psychology class, articles I have read online, podcasts that discuss cognitive bias, and simply lived experience. Witnessing the unfolding of arguments at family gatherings. Watching debates online go absolutely nowhere. Recognizing my own resistance when someone challenges a belief I hold dear.

In what way(s) could I be wrong?

I may be simplifying things too much. It's possible that sometimes what appears to be obstinance is actually a person thinking about social and emotional costs that I am not aware of. I may also be incorrect about how widespread this is, cultural differences likely have a larger role in this than I am accounting for.

What I need to know...

The neurological basis of it, specifically what is firing in the brains of individuals when they encounter information that conflicts with their existing beliefs. In addition, I need to know what works in terms of interventions, currently, I mainly know what does NOT work and that is not particularly helpful.

Where and how I might find the answers to my questions...

Peer reviewed psychology research available through academic databases such as JSTOR or Google Scholar. Books on cognitive science, perhaps something written by Daniel Kahneman or Jonathan Haidt. Possible contact with professors in the psychology department who specialize in studying this topic.

Topic 4

2 or 3 Things I Know For Sure...

There is growing evidence of a rising trend in self-reported loneliness, most notably among younger generations, and this was happening even before the COVID-19 pandemic. I am also aware that using social media is often correlated with feelings of isolation in many studies, even though the primary purpose of these platforms is supposed to be connecting with others. I also know that the health consequences are truly frightening, loneliness can be as damaging as smoking, according to some research.

What I know comes from...

When The Surgeon General issued an advisory about the loneliness epidemic, I started paying closer attention to the issue. I have also noticed personally how disconnected I feel from the hundreds of posts from people I technically "know" but am still completely alone. This disconnect between the number of connections I have and the depth of my connections feels very real to me.

How I might be wrong...

It's possible that loneliness is not actually on the rise, and we are just measuring it differently now or discussing it more openly. Perhaps I am blaming technology for the problem when the underlying issues are economic, people are working more hours, moving more often, and therefore have less time to devote to meaningful relationships. Correlation

does not equal causation and I could be guilty of this fallacy to a large degree.

What I Need To Know...

How researchers define and measure loneliness, as well as how historically social connection has changed, are two areas I need to learn more about. Did people actually have fewer deep relationships in the past or do we simply idealize the past? What kinds of interventions have communities and organizations attempted to reduce loneliness, and did any of them show success?

Where and How I Might Find Answers...

The Surgeon General's advisory report would be a good starting point for researching this topic. Public health journals and sociology databases would also be useful resources. Researching how other countries are addressing this issue may also provide interesting insights. Japan and the U.K., for example, each have government positions dedicated to reducing loneliness.

Topic 3

2 or 3 things I Know for certain...

The idea that people who believe one conspiracy theory will likely believe another; it's almost as if believing in one conspiracy theory is part of a larger way of thinking, rather than a belief in the conspiracy theory itself. I know that when we're in uncertain, fearful situations, pandemics, economic downturns, major political upheavals, that's when conspiracy thinking tends to increase. I also know that calling believers crazy or stupid doesn't work. In fact, it makes it worse.

What I know is from...

Documentary films; articles about psychology; being on Reddit at 2 am and falling down a rabbit hole; seeing in real-time how conspiracy theories exploded with COVID-19, and seeing friends and family members I have respect for fall into these behaviors was scary, and made me want to learn why this happens.

How I may be mistaken...

I may draw too much of a clear line between legitimate skepticism and conspiracy theory. History shows us that sometimes, the people who believed conspiracy theories were right (e.g., government surveillance, corporate cover-ups). I may underestimate how rational some of these beliefs seem to those who hold them... humans are naturally good at recognizing patterns and sometimes that pattern-recognition goes awry.

What I need to know...

What specific psychological needs do conspiracy theories meet? Is it a desire for control? A feeling of being special? An attempt to make sense of the chaos around you? I need to understand the demographics and psychological profiles of those who engage in conspiracy thinking without stereotyping. Most importantly, I need to understand what can help someone step away from conspiratorial thinking and what would push them further into it.

Where and how I can obtain answers...

Research in academic journals in social psychology and political science. There has been an explosion of research in this area since 2020. Reading books such as Conspiracy Theories, by Quassim Cassam will also be valuable. Interviewing or conducting case studies with individuals who have left conspiracy communities, hearing their perspective would be incredibly valuable!

Which topic(s) is(are) sparking my interest? Why?

Topic 1 is where my mind always seems to go. Pure defiance. Topics 2 and 3 both tie directly into Topic 1, conspiracy theories require a resistance to contradictory evidence and loneliness could make people more susceptible to rigid thinking because they've found a sense of community through shared beliefs. This all ties together. Topic 1 feels like the root system that drives everything else, which is why I just cannot get enough of it. Additionally, this is a very personal interest for me because I want to be able to better update my own thoughts/beliefs and understand why it's difficult for me to do so...

Creative expression: Do something creative with one of your topics. (e.g.: create a visual representation of the topic, create a word cloud of ideas, create a slideshow to persuade yourself or your peers that the topic is a good one).

If my research topic were a playlist, these are the songs I'd put on it and why they reflect how I feel about this topic better than any diagram ever could.

"Everybody's Free (To Wear Sunscreen)" by Baz Luhrmann, the line "be careful whose advice you buy" has a different effect when ONE realizes people buy the advice of those with whom they already agree.

"Lose Yourself", Eminem, that one moment in a conversation when you have ONE opportunity to say the correct thing to change someone's mind and you just... Choked. Because the pressure of the conversation swallowed you up.

"We're Not Gonna Take It" by Twisted Sister, this song is literally the anthem of resisting beliefs. Pure defiance. Does not matter what you are saying, I am not listening, and I will be loud about it.

"Mad World" by Gary Jules, for that quiet, sad realization that everyone is walking around thinking they are right about everything, and nobody is really hearing each other.

"Changes" by Tupac, change is possible, but change is slow and painful and most people will rather keep things as they are even when the way things are is broken.

"Comfortably Numb" by Pink Floyd, because that is exactly what staying wrong feels like. Comfortable. Numb. Safe. Why would anybody leave that?